Content for the Webpage

UN Water Conference 2026: Virtual Side Event by WOTR

9th November 2026
2.30 pm to 4:00 pm (GST)
4.30 pm to 6:00 pm (IST)

Securing Drinking Water for All: Strengthening Operation & Maintenance Systems for Sustainable and Climate-Resilient Drinking Water Services under the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) in India

This session will explore innovative, actionable pathways to strengthen and incentivise JJM O&M systems through improved service delivery, water quality, financial and source sustainability, local governance and regulatory measures.

1. The Context of the Session

Access to safe and reliable drinking water is fundamental to human dignity, public health and sustainable development. Under the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), India has made significant investments in rural drinking water infrastructure, with the vision of providing safe and adequate drinking water to every rural household through functional tap connections. However, the long-term success of this ambitious programme depends not only on creating infrastructure but also on ensuring that drinking water systems remain functional, financially viable, inclusive and resilient to climate variability. Strengthening operation and maintenance (O&M) systems is therefore central to ensuring the long-term sustainability of rural drinking water services. This requires a comprehensive approach that integrates technical systems with institutional capacity, community participation, financial planning, source sustainability and evidence-based decision-making.

India's experience under JJM offers important lessons on how government programmes, civil society organisations, technical institutions and local communities can work together to strengthen drinking water governance. Community-led approaches, locally grounded institutional mechanisms and innovative assessment tools can help identify gaps, improve accountability and support the transition towards sustainable service delivery.

2. Purpose of the Event

This virtual event will bring together practitioners, development organisations, researchers and sector experts to share experiences and identify actionable pathways for strengthening O&M systems and local water governance for sustainable rural drinking water services. The event will highlight innovative and community-led approaches that connect service delivery, water quality, financial sustainability, source protection and climate resilience. It will also explore how evidence, digital tools and institutional partnerships can strengthen planning, monitoring and accountability under JJM.

By drawing on experiences from India, the session aims to contribute to the global dialogue on achieving SDG 6: ensuring the availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all, with particular emphasis on the long-term functionality, reliability and resilience of rural drinking water systems.

3. Moderator and Speakers

The 90-minute session will bring together experts representing research, civil society, water-sector organisations and community-led development initiatives.

Session Moderator

Sarah Elser, Coordinator, Global Water and Climate Adaptation Centre (ABCD Centre), Technische Universität Dresden, Germany.

Speakers and Topics

1. Eshwer Kale, Thematic Lead – Water Resources Development and Governance, WOTR Centre for Resilience Studies (W-CReS), India.

Topic: Challenges and Opportunities in Strengthening O&M Systems for Rural Drinking Water Schemes under the Jal Jeevan Mission.

2. Manish Wasuja/Anand Ghodke, WASH Specialist, UNICEF India.

Topic: WASH and Water Quality: Ensuring Safe and Reliable Drinking Water Services for Rural Households

3. Anuj Sharma, Chief Executive Officer, Arghyam, India.
Topic: Achieving Universal and Reliable Drinking Water Services under the Jal Jeevan Mission: Challenges and Opportunities.

4. Sanjay Singh, Secretary, Parmarth Samaj Sevi Sansthan, India.
Topic: Community Institutions and Women's Engagement for Sustainable Rural Drinking Water Services.

5. Harish Daware, Director, Watershed Organisation Trust (WOTR), India.
Topic: Strengthening Drinking Water Sources for Reliable Supply and Long-Term Scheme Sustainability.

6. Priya Agarwal, Food Systems Consultant, India Climate Collaborative (ICC).
Topic: Climate Resilience and Sustainable Financing for Rural Drinking Water Systems.

Key Takeaways and Concluding Remark

Bishwadeep Ghose, Country Director, Water For People, India.

Relevant material: **Jal-Suraksha: Securing Rural Drinking Water Services**

Microsoft Meet link for register and meeting link (QRs)